



#### AGRICULTURE

Natural landscapes are radically altered by intensive farming, such as the cultivation of rice in irrigated terraces throughout Asia. Such methods support big populations, but require large amounts of water.

## EXTINCTION

The inability of many organisms to adapt to environmental change has led to a huge turnover of species throughout geological time. In fact, the vast majority of nature's species are now extinct. Only the fittest organisms survive, usually through gradual adaptation, but sometimes by the sudden elimination of competitors. For example, when a huge asteroid hit Earth 66 million years ago, it set in motion a chain of events that led to the demise of many life forms, including the dinosaurs on land and the ammonites in the seas. But it also opened the way for the rapid evolution of mammals including humans. More recently, the arrival of modern humans in different regions around the world has contributed to the extinction of particular species, such as the woolly mammoth in Europe and Asia (see far right). Today, as the human population expands, our actions are placing a growing number of species, such as the tiger, in imminent danger of extinction.



#### ^ DECLINE OF THE CRESTED IBIS

Once widespread in Asia, hunting and habitat loss has restricted the crested ibis to a small wild population in China. Captive breeding has allowed it to be reintroduced to Japan.

#### < PÈRE DAVID'S DEER

Extinct in the wild, this east Asian deer has survived only in captive herds bred in England since 1900. Père David's deer reintroduced to China in the 1980s now form a population some 700 strong.

## SCIENCE

### MAMMOTHS NO MORE

Woolly mammoths were elephants that were adapted to the cold. They migrated across ice-age Europe and Asia in vast herds. Archaeological evidence such as cave paintings shows that they were actively hunted by humans around 30,000 years ago, which may have contributed to the extinction of most woolly mammoths by 11,000 years ago.



CAVE PAINTING, PECH-MERLE, FRANCE